7.2 Loosen that body



Learning goals

Students

- Are aware of the degrees of freedom in their joints and their relevance for playing.
- Identify how movement in specific joints affects sound production, and adjust playing in response.
- Maintain musical regularity independently of movement in the joints.
- Recognize and release unnecessary physical tension while playing.

Requirements

- Sufficient space for all students

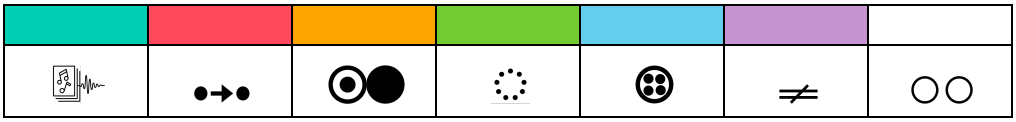
Inspiration

This activity draws on the relationship between expertise and degrees of freedom in the joints. Research shows that novice musicians tend to "freeze" their degrees of freedom — locking their knees, tensing their shoulders — while experts can freeze and release them at will. Developing this flexibility from early on is a central aim of a kinemusical approach.

Physical freedom is essential for expressive and creative music-making. It is also a condition for experiencing the instrument as a natural extension of the body rather than an external object to control. In this process, students engage in an ongoing "negotiation" with the instrument: they discover what movement it allows, what it resists, and how to adjust their playing accordingly.

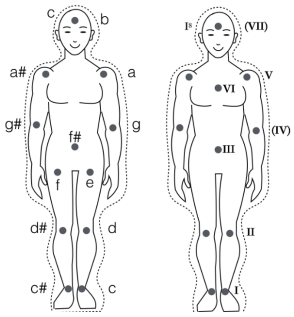
At the same time, loosening the body while playing develops a physical awareness that contributes to a healthier way of playing — for example, by learning to feel where tension accumulates and how to release it.

Constraints



Description

Each joint is linked to a note on a musical scale. While playing a note, the relevant joint is moved to explore its degrees of freedom.



Connecting the different joints to musical notes (left) or grades (right) of a scale.

Variations

- Increase the complexity of the musical patterns played per joint..
  - Alternate 2 notes
    - ➛ *first seconds and then more difficult intervals*
  - 3 notes up and down
    - ➛ *first consecutive notes, then add intervals so that you can play, for example, a broken chord or other motif in a loop*
  - From easy to difficult rhythms
- Use different tempos.
- dd a dynamic pattern (<, >, <>, ><) or alternate dynamics (*p, mf, f*).

Good to know …

On the one hand, playing one note per joint draws attention to the interface between musician and instrument and to the changes in sound (e.g., timbre, intonation) that result from the movement. On the other hand, playing more complicated musical patterns can address other aspects of performance, such as regularity or phrasing. At the same time, this can facilitate the automation of a musical passage.